

Episode 11: Once Upon a Time... (8) The Treacherous Small Bottles

After returning from Seoul, Tokyo has gotten cold somehow.

What surprised me during last week's Seoul business trip was mobile phones. I didn't know! Recent Japanese mobile phones can be used overseas!

The production staff K-san who went to Seoul with me received calls from Tokyo on his mobile phone as if nothing had happened, and emails too. Ah, it's somehow frustrating, or rather, enviable. My mobile phone was only useful as an alarm clock in Seoul.

So I've decided to change my phone model next time I go overseas! (laughs)

...But when exactly is "next time I go overseas"? (bitter laugh)

Well then.

About paints. Did you know? Paints are "perishable goods."

I have no idea what raw materials are actually used, but cel paints would grow mould and rot. STAC paints especially were thoroughly "perishable goods."

When you go to art supply stores in town, sometimes they sell animation cels and cel paints. The cel paints sold there come in tiny small bottles, but for our work painting purposes, those are definitely too small (laughs). We use bigger small bottles. Glass bottles about the size of small coffee cans, or slightly shorter poly bottles with thicker circumferences, filled with paints and arranged around each person's painting

desk for easy use. **These small bottles of paint sometimes set various traps waiting for us (laughs).**

First, the fragrance - or rather, smell.

Cel paints had a somewhat sweet fragrance, and I loved that smell. What was it like? You know how new vinyl products have that faintly sweet smell? It was like that. Every time we painted colours, every time we opened paint lids and stirred, the paint's fragrant smell would rise (laughs). It was a moment where I felt just a little bit happy.

However. Sometimes, betrayals awaited that would trample that moment of ecstasy.

"Ugh (sweat)"

That sweet fragrance would suddenly change. The paint itself was emitting a foul odour. That smell was exactly like rotten eggs! When you come back from lunch and open paint that smells like this with a "Here we go!", honestly, it makes you cry.

Not all colours would become like this - it was more likely to happen with indigo-type NR series paints and beautiful pink PB series paints, specifically the darker colours in those ranges.

Next troublesome thing was mould.

Paints have different usage frequencies depending on colour. Depending on the works coming in at the time, colours divide into frequently used and not-so-frequently used. For some colours, it wasn't uncommon to not even open the lid for a month or so.

Then one day, when you open the lid of a colour you haven't used in a while...

Fluffy.

Dense white mould covering the paint surface (laughs). Long-haired white mould had grown. You wanted to touch that fluffiness (laughs). Since it only grew on the surface touching air, you'd press the glass rod used for stirring between the jar's inner surface and the mould, then turn it around once. Then "plop" - the mould covering the paint surface like an inner lid would come off cleanly. Since only the surface was mouldy, you could just throw away that part and use the paint normally.

Incidentally, this glass rod used for stirring was a drafting tool called a "groove ruler." Many people think it's a rod for stirring paint, but when drawing straight lines with drafting pens using rulers, you use this rod like chopsticks to draw lines.

But well, mould was still cute.

Similarly opening paint lids and trying to stir with glass rods, sometimes there would be squishy lumps on the surface. Jellyfish-like gelatinous substances floating on the paint surface. Sometimes, like with mould, they'd cover the entire surface like an inner lid.

The cause was probably decay. This was the troublemaker! If it had grown to cover the entire surface, you could throw away that part with a "plop" like with mould, but if you stirred the paint without noticing when it was still small and just beginning, that substance would be nicely stirred throughout the entire paint, making all the paint rot.

What happens then?

The entire paint becomes slimy to the touch, paint on brush tips starts stringing, and on cel surfaces the paint won't spread properly, making it hard to paint. Some colours would even darken. Once it reached this state, it was over. That paint went to the trash.

Cel paints varied in condition according to each user's preferences. Some people found it easier to paint with more moisture in a looser state, while others preferred it harder for vigorous painting. So depending on that water balance, mouldiness and rotting tendencies probably varied too.

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